

Chapter 123 - Black Scales

The woman's slender and soft body actively drew close, as unbelievable as the sun setting in the east. Ning Fuyi was pulled by her into a stumble, her chest full of warmth.

The ice on the snowy mountain peak was melted by sunlight, flowing down the mountain in streams, moistening the dark and cracked earth at the mountain's foot.

Ning Fuyi's heart was filled with tenderness. She raised her hand to embrace Chu Qingqiu's back, feeling beautiful bone structure beneath the burning skin.

Her fingertips traced over the bones: "But I like it."

Ning Fuyi rubbed her cheek against her temple, patiently saying, "Chu Qingqiu, love, hate, anger, and obsession¹ - there's no sin in them."

"I won't dislike you being this way either. The shackles on you are too heavy and complicated. If you could appropriately remove some of them, it would be good for you."

Chu Qingqiu hugged her waist tightly and shook her head: "Won't you find me too difficult to get along with?"

"You're so wonderful - what's the harm in being a little difficult?" Ning Fuyi felt that the Chu Qingqiu before her seemed to overlap with Su Mo for an instant. In her daze, she continued, "You're used to scolding me, so scold me if you want. I'm used to being disciplined by you anyway."

"I don't want to." Chu Qingqiu let go of her, her peach blossom eyes misty with fog. "I want to treat you well."

Hearing her say this, Ning Fuyi's smile couldn't stop curving upward. Finally, she simply stopped hiding it and, holding her waist, said with a smile: "Do you want me to teach you how to treat me?"

Chu Qingqiu's red lips moved. She calmly brushed her hand away, then suddenly stepped forward, placed her hand behind her head, and looked up to kiss her.

Chu Qingqiu's lips were as soft and sweet as always, like a flower petal falling on her lips, but after stirring up a heartfelt of palpitations, she only tasted briefly before stopping.

"Just like this?" Ning Fuyi hadn't even reacted before only fragrance remained on her lips. She pitifully tugged at her sleeve, only to be ruthlessly swatted away by the woman.

"Let's go. This place is truly filthy." Chu Qingqiu said, walking out the threshold with her hands behind her back. She coldly glanced at the two lustful ghosts, frightening them into stopping in place, not daring to move.

Watching Chu Qingqiu's disgusted figure stride away, Ning Fuyi laughed until her cheeks ached, then ran after her with small steps.

After walking out of the house, the miasma had already disappeared by seventy or eighty percent, and the ruins gradually revealed their outlines. The two originally planned to return first to find the others, but after walking just a short distance, they suddenly heard shouting, followed by a rustling sound approaching from far to near.

That sound didn't seem like people walking, but rather like something crawling on the ground.

Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu nimbly hid behind several roof beams, observing through the gaps.

After half a cup of tea's time, the sound was already close at hand. First, a black columnar body emerged before their eyes, covered with pitch-black scales.

As Ning Fuyi was surprised, she made a hand gesture: "It's a snake."

Such a thick snake must have lived for hundreds if not thousands of years.

The black snake swayed its massive body, slowly swimming on the dim street filled with heavy fog - a scene both oppressive and eerie.

The more eerie scene was yet to come. After the giant snake passed by, a twisted human face actually appeared on its tail. Chu Qingqiu instinctively curled her palm, and Ning Fuyi reached over to take her hand.

That face had obviously been torn from a body, bloody and with an expression still frozen in extreme terror.

Chu Qingqiu clearly hadn't caught her breath properly. It took a long while before her breathing stabilized.

"That face looks familiar..." After the snake completely left their sight, Ning Fuyi spoke quietly. Suddenly, inspiration flashed, and she got goosebumps all over. "I remember now - it's a disciple from Tianxuan Sword Sect!"

"Will the others be in danger?" Ning Fuyi's heart leaped up, but she was pulled back to her original position by Chu Qingqiu.

"There are more sounds." Chu Qingqiu said.

As soon as she finished speaking, the rustling sound reached Ning Fuyi's ears as well. It was another black snake of similar size to the previous one, its tail similarly dragging a person - fine cloud brocade made dirty by mud, being dragged along like a dead thing.

It was Hua Feiwu!

Fortunately, his head and body were still together. Ning Fuyi watched the black snake disappear into the distance and stood up: "Looking at this, the news that the so-called Xuanyuan Kingdom was completely destroyed isn't quite accurate."

"Indeed." Chu Qingqiu frowned as she looked toward the two snakes hidden in the mist. "However, having someone lead the way isn't necessarily a bad thing."

After saying this, she was about to follow, but Ning Fuyi suddenly grabbed her and said in a low voice: "Divine Venerable, since Hua Feiwu was captured, it proves that Wenzhu and the others must have encountered danger. I'm somewhat worried."

Chu Qingqiu looked at her and didn't say much: "Then we'll split up. You go find Sect Leader Tang, and I'll follow them."

"No." Ning Fuyi held onto her wrist and wouldn't let go. "You go find Sect Leader Tang, and I'll go find the black snake."

"You want to disobey again..." Chu Qingqiu said half her words before stopping, her eyes wandering.

"I'll leave traces along the way. After finding the others, use them to come find me."

Ning Fuyi smiled. She pulled Chu Qingqiu's hand over and stuffed something cold into her palm, then raised her hand to touch the top of her head: "I can handle it. Be good."

After saying this, she took off running. Her black clothes quickly merged with the mist.

Chu Qingqiu's hand was still extended in mid-air. Her brow furrowed for a moment, but she couldn't get angry. She said quietly: "How impertinent."

She opened her hand, and a piece of emerald green mixed with gold came into view.

Holding that jade bracelet she'd been separated from for many years, she suddenly felt a surge of emotions and smiled.

Ning Fuyi walked alone in the boundless fog, her steps light and silent. The massive black shadows of the two giant snakes ahead never left her sight as they crawled silently forward.

The black snakes nimbly avoided some obstacles, and there were no demons or monsters intercepting them along the way. Ning Fuyi followed them almost smoothly all the way to a building.

When she could fully see the building's entire appearance, Ning Fuyi couldn't help but marvel inwardly. The ancient fortress before her was as majestic as a stairway to heaven, with a heavenly stone pillar on each side. The pillars were carved full of eye-shaped totems, which were made somewhat distorted by the swirling smoke and looked as if they had come alive, densely staring at visitors.

Fortunately, Ning Fuyi couldn't sense any aura from them, or she would have suspected that hundreds of eyes were really watching her.

After the black snakes reached the base of the stone pillars, they somehow triggered a mechanism. The stone door slowly descended under the pulling of iron chains, and the two black snakes entered one after another.

Ning Fuyi leaped through the stone door at the last moment. She thought the two black snakes would have some awareness, but who knew they continued forward as if they couldn't see anything around them.

Ning Fuyi suspiciously continued hiding her aura and simply hung onto the snake's tail, pretending to be a captive being brought into the fortress.

Although there were signs of decay everywhere inside, one could see the exquisite craftsmanship from thousands of years ago. Two corridors hung in mid-air on the left and right, encircling the stone walls. Occasionally, one could see one or two broken lantern frames hanging there forlornly.

In the center of the fortress was a tower-shaped building, similarly carved full of totems. The black snake entered the tower, and Ning Fuyi also grabbed onto the snake's tail and followed inside. Beside her, the unconscious Hua Feiwu was foaming at the mouth. Ning Fuyi disgustedly turned his face to the other side.

As soon as she entered the tower, Ning Fuyi felt the surrounding temperature suddenly rise. She couldn't help but remember the time she fell into the tiger's den. The current scene was particularly similar to before, except there were no mournful vengeful spirits, and the firelight wasn't bright yellow or red, but tinged with pale blue.

There was nothing else in the tower except a several-zhang-wide towering furnace. Stone steps were carved on both sides of the furnace for going up and down.

The first snake crawled around the furnace in a circle, then raised its tail and threw the head down. Ning Fuyi couldn't see the specific scene, only heard a faint sizzling sound.

Then the snake carrying her did the same thing. Ning Fuyi finally got a clear view of the scene inside the furnace. The flames were completely ice-blue, and when approaching them, a kind of fear that seemed capable of devouring everything crept up her heart.

Ning Fuyi immediately summoned her Emei thorns and forcefully stabbed them into the black snake's tough skin. Lightning crackled from the tip of the Emei thorns, coursing through the snake's tendons throughout its body. The black snake immediately began convulsing, and its tail loosened accordingly.

Ning Fuyi grabbed Hua Feiwu and jumped down from the furnace. As she landed, the black snake crashed into the ice-blue flames. Those flames were indeed terrifying - such a massive body couldn't withstand even half an instant and disappeared without a trace in the blink of an eye.

Only leaving behind a soft "sizzle."

Only then did the other black snake belatedly discover her presence. It raised its head toward her and charged, while Ning Fuyi casually threw Hua Feiwu into a corner, leaped up, and led the snake back onto the furnace.

With another small "sizzle," she effortlessly dealt with another snake, then stood on the edge of the furnace, frowning as she looked down.

The churning ice-blue flames should have been magnificent and mysterious, but every time she approached, they made her panic from the bottom of her heart.

So she stared for a moment, then decisively left quickly.

After moving away from the strange fire, even the polluted air outside the tower seemed fresher. Ning Fuyi dragged the unconscious "burden" in her hand and was troubled for a while, then looked up and saw a latrine built of thatch, suddenly having an idea.

Half an incense stick's time later, Ning Fuyi covered Hua Feiwu's feet with the last handful of straw and satisfactorily dusted off her robe.

Anyway, this person often spoke foulness from his mouth - having him smell more unclean odors might eliminate some of it.

At this time, several more people entered through the stone door. Ning Fuyi immediately turned and hid in a corner, watching them walk past her.

Those people were all wearing black cloaks that covered their heads and faces. They didn't discover Ning Fuyi, nor did they discover Hua Feiwu stuffed in the latrine, and went straight toward the depths of the fortress.

Ning Fuyi looked up, slipped into the corridor, and silently followed.

They entered a stone house in the corner. Ning Fuyi lightly jumped a few times onto the roof and looked inside through a crack in the roof.

The stone house was dark and spacious, with only a torch stuck in the wall providing barely enough light. Chains extended from each of the four corners of the stone house, jointly restraining a person.

That person was curled up facing the other side. From the graceful figure, it was a woman. Her black hair was stained with a lot of dust and grass, half scattered on the ground, half covering her shoulders.

Under her hair, her clothes were disheveled, and one could vaguely see pale tender skin with traces of blood marks all over.

Ning Fuyi immediately felt something was wrong. Her hands gripping the crack used more force. Just then, the leading cloaked figure reached out to flip the woman over, revealing a pale and beautiful face.

Jiang Li!

Ning Fuyi's lips parted slightly, then she angrily clenched her teeth. Her hand unconsciously touched the ring of her Emei thorns, killing intent pervading her heart.

"Do we really have to kill this person? If Black Scales² blames us, we few can't beat her!" The person at the back spoke.

"What if we don't kill her? If Lord Wen Yao³ blames us, can you bear the responsibility?" The leader scolded, then used his withered hand to forcefully slap Jiang Li's cheek. "What a pity for such a beautiful face!"

After saying this, he suddenly drew his sword and gestured around the woman's throat. Ning Fuyi was just about to stop him when she heard the sound of wind passing by. She quickly slipped down behind the stone house and hid.

The door was slammed open with a bang. There was only a scream and several muffled groans, followed by the sound of snakes crawling.

Ning Fuyi saw from afar several smaller black snakes crawl into the stone house, then come out again coiled around several corpses, going straight into the high tower with the furnace.

After she could no longer hear any movement, Ning Fuyi flipped back onto the roof.

Another person was already standing in the stone chamber - dressed entirely in black, wearing snake-skin arm guards on both hands, with curled long hair hanging down to her waist and an ancient silver dagger hanging from her waist.

She stood silently beside Jiang Li, then took out a bottle from somewhere, half-crouched down, and grabbed Jiang Li's hair to drag her upright.

Jiang Li was obviously extremely weak. She was powerless to resist Black Scales' force and was almost entirely lifted by her to kneel.

Jiang Li usually dressed neatly and elegantly, with the bearing of a doctor, naturally standing with immortal grace. But now her hands and feet were bound, her dress was torn, and her lips were swollen. It was heartbreaking to see.

Ning Fuyi was already poised and ready, vigilantly watching Black Scales' next move.

"This is medicine. Take it." Black Scales said in a low voice, then used her finger to flick open the bottle stopper.

Jiang Li struggled to open her eyes and said softly: "Little Black Snake, you've returned."

Upon hearing this, the atmospheric pressure around Black Scales immediately dropped several degrees. She silently let go of Jiang Li, then forcefully pinched both sides of her cheeks and poured the medicine into Jiang Li's mouth, choking her into coughing fits with tears streaming down her face.

"I told you that you've got the wrong person." Black Scales crushed the medicine bottle into powder and let go, throwing the frail woman back to her feet.

1. **Love, hate, anger, and obsession (爱恨嗔痴)** - These are the four fundamental emotions/afflictions in Buddhist philosophy, often considered sources of suffering but here presented as natural human emotions without inherent sin.
2. **Black Scales (黑鳞)** - This is the person's name/title, referring to someone with black scales, likely indicating their serpentine nature.
3. **Lord Wen Yao (文曜君)** - A high-ranking official or noble from Penglai, as established in previous chapters.